

Say vs Tell

CEFR A2

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

The simple rule is about who follows the verb:

- 1 Tell + person — She told me a secret (you must name the person).
- 2 Say (+ to + person) — She said hello; She said (that) it was late.

Fixed phrases to memorise: tell the truth / a lie / a story / the time, but say sorry / hello / a word / nothing.

At a glance

	Say	Tell
Person after the verb?	no (or 'to' + person)	yes — always
Example	She said she was tired.	She told me she was tired.
With 'to'	She said hello to him.	— (never 'told to me')
Fixed phrases	say hello, say sorry, say a word	tell the truth, tell a story, tell the time

Learning objectives

- Can apply the rule 'tell + person' vs 'say (+ to + person)' (CEFR A2).
- Can use the common fixed phrases with say and tell.
- Can avoid 'say me' and 'tell to me'.



Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Say vs Tell · CEFR A2

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. She ____ me the good news.

A. said

C. said to

B. told

D. telled

2. He ____ that he was tired.

A. told

C. told me

B. said

D. say

3. Please ____ the truth.

A. say

C. say to

B. tell

D. tell to

4. Did you ____ hello to your parents?

A. tell

C. told

B. say

D. say to

5. Correct this: 'He said me to wait.'

A. He told me to wait.

C. He say me to wait.

B. He said to me to wait.

D. The sentence is already correct.

6. Children love it when you ____ them a story.

A. say

C. say to

B. tell

D. tell to

7. She didn't ____ a word all evening.

A. tell

C. told

B. say

D. said to

8. Can you ____ me the time, please?

A. say

C. say to

B. tell

D. told

9. He ____ goodbye and left.

A. told

C. told me

B. said

D. tell

10. Which sentence is correct?

A. She told to me she was happy.

C. She told me she was happy.

B. She said me she was happy.

D. She said me that she was happy.

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **B. told** — A person straight after the verb takes 'tell': 'She told me the news'.
2. **B. said** — No person after the verb takes 'say': 'He said that he was tired'.
3. **B. tell** — The fixed phrase is 'tell the truth'.
4. **B. say** — The fixed phrase is 'say hello (to someone)'.
5. **A. He told me to wait.** — A person after the verb + a command takes 'tell': 'He told me to wait'.
6. **B. tell** — 'Tell + person + a story': 'tell them a story'.
7. **B. say** — The fixed phrase is 'say a word': 'She didn't say a word'.
8. **B. tell** — 'Tell the time' + person: 'tell me the time'.
9. **B. said** — The fixed phrase is 'say goodbye': 'He said goodbye and left'.
10. **C. She told me she was happy.** — 'Tell + person': 'She told me she was happy'.